



Fasting and Feasting

Lesson 20 Questions

First Day: Read Lesson 19 Notes.

The notes and lecture fortify the truth of the passage for understanding and application to daily life.

1. How did the lecture help you understand Christ's role as your Priest and King?
2. What truths from the notes helped tie together God's message through Zechariah's visions?

Second Day: Read Zechariah 7:1-7.

A question posed to Zechariah brought God's challenge regarding empty religious rituals.

3. Compare Zechariah 1:1 with 7:1. How much time had passed, and what was happening in Jerusalem by then? (See also Ezra 5:1-2, 16; 6:15.)
4. a. What did the delegation from Bethel ask?
Note: During the 70-year Babylonian exile, the Israelites established several fasts commemorating their losses—beyond the one fast God commanded on the Day of Atonement (Leviticus 23:27).

b. How did God's answer redirect their question?

5. a. Why might we be drawn to religious rituals rather than heartfelt worship and service to God?
- b. In what ways can self-focus hinder your worship and service for God?

Third Day: Read Zechariah 7:8-14.

God called His people to live differently than their ancestors.

6. a. What are the positive and negative commands in verses 8-10?
 - b. How do these commands demonstrate a heart and life God has transformed?
(See also James 1:27.)
 - c. What might a person's response to the most vulnerable among society reveal about him or her?
7. a. How had God's people responded to His mercy in the past?
 - b. What was the result?
8. In what ways has God molded your character through lessons learned from your own mistakes or those of others?

Fourth Day: Read Zechariah 8:1-15.

God promised blessings for His people and their city.

9. Explain God's response toward Zion (the mountain on which Jerusalem sits) and her people expressed in verse 2. (See also Nahum 1:2 and Zechariah 1:14-15.)
10. Look for the repeated phrase, "This is what the LORD Almighty says," and summarize what God promises His people. *Note:* Many of the promises extend beyond Zechariah's day to the Messiah's reign on earth.

11. How would these promises have given hope to the returned exiles who sought to rebuild Jerusalem?

12. a. How do the verses in this section confirm the promise given to Abraham in Genesis 12:1-3?

b. How might your life bless those around you?

Fifth Day: Read Zechariah 8:16-23.

The Lord promised to transform Israel's fasts to feasts.

13. From these verses, what does the Lord hate? What does He call His people to love?

14. a. What answer does God give in verse 19 to the question posed in 7:3?

b. Give some ways the Lord turns mourning into joy in a believer's life. (See also Isaiah 61:1-3 and 2 Corinthians 4:17-18.)

c. How can you find joy in the heaviest burden you carry today?

15. From verses 20-23, how will the people of the world respond to God's people?

Sixth Day: Review Zechariah 7–8.

God calls people out of empty religion into a vibrant relationship with Him.

16. How did the Lord convict or encourage you in these chapters?

Homiletics for Group and Administrative Leaders: Zechariah 7–8

Next step: Listen to the lecture.

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Next step: Read the lesson notes.

Lesson 20 Notes

Zechariah 7–8

Focus Verse

“This is what the LORD Almighty says: ‘The fasts of the fourth, fifth, seventh and tenth months will become joyful and glad occasions and happy festivals for Judah. Therefore love truth and peace.’” (Zechariah 8:19)

Outline

- Fasting: The Puzzling Question – Zechariah 7
- Feasting: The Promised Restoration – Zechariah 8

Engage

How can we know if we are truly serving God or just ourselves? Self-absorption, a by-product of humanity’s fall into sin, deeply infects our approach to everything and everyone in our lives. We can easily do the right things for the wrong reasons. Even God-ordained disciplines can become rote exercises devoid of heart connection with Him. Maintaining a checklist of prescribed behaviors makes us feel successful and appeals to our pride. A system we can control and calculate seems easier than wholehearted surrender to a God who is beyond us in every way.

Serving God involves more than going through the motions and adhering to a religious system.

Zechariah’s eight nighttime visions invited God’s people to consider His unfolding plan. With work on the temple resumed, they wondered what serving and worshipping God should now look like. When a curious delegation posed a practical question to Zechariah, God offered a challenging answer. He steadily propelled His people forward in faith and obedience. He reminded them of the nation’s past judgment and future blessings. He called them to seek Him, not through external formalities but from the heart. **God calls people out of empty religion into a vibrant relationship with Him.** He desires spiritual reality, not superficial rituals. God has great things in store for His people as they humbly serve Him and others.

● Fasting: The Puzzling Question – Zechariah 7

Zechariah 7–8 forms a bridge between Zechariah’s first sermon and eight visions recorded in chapters 1–6 and the prophecy recorded in chapters 9–14. Though the message in chapters 7–8 comes in plain speech that seems easier to understand than the other chapters in the book, the themes unfolded through the eight visions continue here. Concerned not just for the temple’s physical restoration but God’s work within His people, Zechariah’s next words point toward a practical outworking of the truth God had revealed.

The Question: Should Our Fasting Continue? – 7:1-3

Zechariah's message regarding fasting came two years after he received his visions and symbolically crowned Joshua. Zechariah chronicled the date of this oracle. He cited the reigning Persian king (Darius) and the month of Kislev (November or December).

The work on Jerusalem's temple had steadily progressed; when Zechariah wrote chapters 7–8, the project was about halfway completed.¹ As the temple building rose, the people surely anticipated resuming the ancient feasts ordained by God's law.² **God's evident blessing led a delegation from Bethel to ask Zechariah a practical question.** Located about 10 miles (16 km) from Jerusalem, Bethel had a history of idolatry and disregard of God. Jeroboam had established idolatrous worship of golden calves in Bethel.³ Some people with origins in Bethel had returned from Babylonian exile with Zerubbabel.⁴

This delegation from Bethel asked Israel's priests and prophets, "Should I mourn and fast in the fifth month, as I have done for so many years?" In other words, now that they had returned from exile and lived in their homeland with temple construction underway, should they stop grieving as they had while in Babylon?

Fasting involves intentional self-denial, usually abstaining from food and other comforts to demonstrate repentance and seek God's favor. The law God gave to Moses required only one annual fast—on the Day of Atonement.⁵ **During their 70-year Babylonian exile, God's people established a series of fasts commemorating the fall of Jerusalem to mourn their many losses.** The following fasts, listed below in order of key events surrounding Judah's fall to Babylon, were added to their annual calendar:

- In the 10th month, the beginning of the Babylonian siege on Jerusalem (2 Kings 25:1; Jeremiah 39:1; 52:4-5)
- In the fourth month, the enemy's breach of Jerusalem's wall (Jeremiah 39:1-4; 52:6-9)
- In the fifth month, the burning of the Jerusalem temple (2 Kings 25:8-9)
- In the seventh month, the assassination of the governor Gedaliah (Jeremiah 41:1-10)

The Israelites' recent blessings made them question their need to mourn past miseries. These fasts had become yearly rituals, as all spontaneity and true seeking of God devolved into mere outward performance of a dead formality. Therefore, the Jews asked Zechariah if they should continue these observances. Interestingly, God's answer does not appear until later in the sermon, in Zechariah 8:18-19. Instead, the Lord's attention shifts the focus to a weightier matter.

Zechariah's response to this question came from the Lord Himself, as verified several times throughout these two chapters.⁶ **God clearly spoke through His prophet and into this question with divine authority.** God is not removed from our day-to-day situations or our genuine questions. God's people should seek to apply His wisdom as they honor Him in matters of daily life and wholehearted worship.

1. **Temple reconstruction:** Ezra 5:16; 6:15

2. **Feasts:** Leviticus 23

3. **Bethel's idolatrous past:** 1 Kings 12:26-33

4. **Returnees from Bethel:** Ezra 2:1-2, 28

5. **Day of Atonement:** Leviticus 23:27

6. **The Word of the Lord:** Zechariah 7:4, 8; 8:1, 4, 6, 7, 9, 14, 18, 19, 20, 23

The Response: Whom Were You Really Serving? – 7:4-10

Self-Centered Religion (7:4-7) – Rather than immediately giving clear direction regarding the established fasts, God asked penetrating questions that bore deeply into the heart of the matter.

“When you fasted and mourned in the fifth and seventh months for the past seventy years, was it really for me that you fasted?” God’s concern was not for their outward actions but for the posture of their hearts before Him. Instead of commending them for keeping these sorrowful fasts for seven decades, he condemned the sham externalism of their seemingly pious acts. As they beat their breasts, rejected food, and set aside a day for formal mourning, whom did they seek to please? Did they merely celebrate their own self-pity for personal and national tragedies?

God’s system of laws that ordered Israel’s lives and worship had always been aimed at transforming hearts, not merely regulating behavior. However, sin’s corruption within humanity runs so deep that self-focus distorts even our best intentions. **Religious observances, church attendance, service to others, and spiritual disciplines greatly contribute to our walk with the Lord but can easily be twisted to feed our sinful pride.** As people with hearts set on serving God, we do well to guard against the constant siren call of the human flesh.⁷

Overemphasis on outward spiritual rituals without a corresponding internal reality of true repentance and seeking God leads to empty formalities that exalt people rather than God. Isaiah 58:3-9 contains a similar rebuke for fasting performed as an empty external ritual. In that passage, God condemned those who piously participated in fasts yet continued to exploit workers and treat others with injustice. They performed their religious duties but continued to live as they pleased.

God’s rebuke through Zechariah also denounced their feasts. Eating, drinking, and celebrating also fed their selfish motives. God delights when we mourn and celebrate in ways that honor Him. Certainly, life in this fallen world offers ample reasons to mourn and cry out to God. God also enriches our lives with blessings for which we offer praise—the rising sun, falling rain, faithful friends, delicious food, and abundant grace. However, God calls His people to align their hearts with Him. **Empty rituals that serve only to make us feel better do not honor God but ourselves.**

Transforming Faith (7:8-10) – God’s word to Zechariah continued to press in and expose God’s heart’s desire for His people. Instead of ritualistic fasting, God seeks hearts and lives that abstain from personal sin against Him and our neighbors. **Truly pleasing God cannot be quantified by external participation in religious ceremonies.** God is greatly pleased with lives that demonstrate the transformation only He can bring to human hearts.

In these verses, God defines the practice of faith that pleases Him. He offers two positive commands and two negative commands pointing to God-pleasing obedience. God’s people mirror His heart as they “administer true justice” and “show mercy and compassion to one another.” They demonstrate His character when they refuse to oppress widows, the fatherless, foreigners, or the poor. God also charges His people not to plot evil against each other.

Hearts transformed by God’s mercy extend compassion and support to the most vulnerable in society. By contrast, wicked worldly systems boldly prey on the weak. Redeemed minds notice injustice and actively promote God-pleasing justice. To declare love for God and yet walk piously past the suffering and oppressed people of this world does not represent God or His heart for humanity.

7. No longer living for self: 2 Corinthians 5:15

Scripture frequently calls people to an internal spiritual reality that transforms their daily lives.⁸ James 1:27 concludes the same: “Religion that God our Father accepts as pure and faultless is this: to look after orphans and widows in their distress and to keep oneself from being polluted by the world.”

This teaching challenges us, as people who often prefer formulas that instantly bring desired results. **It is far easier to perform empty rituals than yield our lives to God and serve others.** We cannot claim to love God while living in a self-satisfied bubble. We live in a world surrounded by people in great need. God has uniquely positioned you to represent Him in the place He has stationed you. How will you respond?

Lessons from the Past – 7:11-14

Persistent Rebellion (7:11-13) – Zechariah’s God-given message again points to the past failures of God’s people as a sober warning. They had deliberately rejected God and His ways. They had refused to pay attention, stubbornly turned their backs, and covered their ears. Their foolish hearts had become hard like flint when they refused to listen to the Lord’s words spoken by His prophets. Their persistent refusal to turn to God ignited His righteous anger and brought His promised judgment.

People Scattered (7:14) – As promised, God scattered His rebellious people through the nations, as if by a whirlwind. Their land was left desolate, a fact Zechariah’s contemporaries would readily acknowledge. **Turning away from God and spurning His mercy reaps devastating results.**

The Bethel delegation did not receive a simple answer to their practical question. Instead, God challenged their thinking, calling them to examine their hearts as they considered previous failures and present consequences. While chapter 7 communicates a negative answer to their question, chapter 8 turns the focus to positive expectations of restoration.

● Feasting: The Promised Restoration – Zechariah 8

God’s answer to the people’s question concerning ritual fasts involved more than a call beyond their absorption with past events and dreadful punishment. **With overflowing love for His people, God also turned their focus to the wonderful future He had in store for them.** Mournful fasts would be transformed into joyous festivals. This entire chapter presents a glorious picture of life lived in the certainty of God’s will and purposes.

The name *Yahweh* (translated “LORD” in the NIV) occurs 22 times in this chapter. The phrase “The word of the LORD Almighty came to me” introduces two sections of this chapter. God’s promises stand firmly on His character and purposes. **Repeatedly and in various ways, the Lord reminded the people of His presence, promising that He was with them, among them, and returning to bless them and make them a blessing.**⁹ God’s promises for Zechariah’s day merge with His ultimate promises for the future, even to the days of the millennium. For instance, verses 7-8 refer to Israel’s restoration and conversion, which still await complete fulfillment.

8. **More than rituals:** 1 Samuel 15:22-23; Amos 5:21-27; Micah 6:6-8; Matthew 9:13

9. **Promises of blessing:** Zechariah 8:3, 7-8, 11-13, 15, 23

A Joyous Time of God's Abundant Blessings

The Doctrine of the Millennium

The promises God gave His people through Zechariah point to a future of overflowing joy and abundance in a restored city. God will dwell among His people without the threat of enemies or the weight of their painful past. **Because all these promises were not fully realized in Zechariah's time, many believe they point to the future—the millennium—a time described in Revelation 20:1-6.**

"Millennium" comes from a Latin word meaning "thousand years." At this time, Jesus Christ will reign over the entire earth at the end of human history before the creation of the new heaven and earth.

Sincere Christians hold varying views regarding the millennium. Amillennialism, meaning "no millennium," does not see in Scripture a literal thousand-year physical reign but rather a symbol of Christ's spiritual reign in the hearts of His people until He returns. Postmillennialism interprets the one thousand years as earth's golden age resulting from the transformational spread of the gospel. Premillennialism looks for Christ to return and then establish His earthly rule for one thousand years, during which time Satan will be bound.¹ He will then be released before he is vanquished for eternity,² which will inaugurate the new heaven and new earth.³ This view incorporates many Old Testament promises for Israel, such as those recorded in Zechariah.⁴ Bible Study Fellowship graciously holds the premillennial view while recognizing varying opinions.

Without understanding the harmony and victory Christ will bring to earth, society's trajectory seems rather dismal. Knowing that Christ will reign, abolish Satan's strongholds, and bring peace to His people offers hope. To ignore Christ's promise and rightful authority to reign and rule results in a limited view of God's revealed plan for humanity. Without grasping what God has revealed about the future, today and tomorrow seem haphazard and God's role and involvement feel distant at best.

Understanding God's plan to end strife and bring justice offers believers hope as we process the chaos that surrounds us. Living with promises that are not yet fulfilled but still certain grants us needed perspective. **God has told us enough about the future to establish our focus on His promised victory.** Even without full insight into when and how these things will come to pass, we can rest assured that God will accomplish everything He has promised. Zechariah wrote, "This is what the LORD Almighty says: 'It may seem marvelous to the remnant of this people at that time, but will it seem marvelous to me?'"⁵ We can trust God with what we know and what we cannot fully comprehend. Our hope and comfort cannot be found in promising political leaders, new ideas to address age-old ills, or fearful self-preservation. Only God can deliver what we long for. And He will!

1. **Satan bound:** Revelation 20:1-6

2. **Satan defeated:** Revelation 20:7-10

3. **New heaven and new earth:** Revelation 21:1-8

4. **Old Testament promises:** Isaiah 2:1-4; Jeremiah 31:31-34; Romans 11:25-27

5. **God's promises fulfilled:** Zechariah 8:6

Reasons for Hope – 8:1-17

God's Faithfulness (8:1-8) – In verse 2, the Lord declared He was “burning with jealousy” for Zion. The intensity of this expression communicates God’s fury against the nations who mistreated Israel and His desire for His people’s undivided affections and consecration. **The promises God made to Israel rest on His abundant love for His people.**

The Lord promised to return to Zion and dwell in Jerusalem. God’s previous departure from the city was depicted in Ezekiel’s vision of God’s departing glory from both the temple and city when the 70 long years in exile began.¹⁰ Ezekiel also had a vision of God’s returning glory.¹¹ This promise extends beyond Zechariah’s time and the exiles’ return to Jerusalem from Babylonian captivity. Jerusalem will be called “the Faithful City,” and the mountain of the Lord will be called “the Holy Mountain,” the full impact of which will be realized only when Messiah reigns from Jerusalem to govern the world. At that time, Jerusalem will be known for truth and holiness. Zechariah later noted that even the bells on the horses and cooking pots in Jerusalem will portray holiness.¹² The remnant in Israel will no longer speak lies or act in iniquity but will be known for truth and fidelity.¹³

Verses 4-5 paint a beautiful picture many Bible students see as future—to be fulfilled in the millennium. No longer in survival mode, people of all ages will flourish in the security and joy of God’s interest, love, and care. The preciousness of the young¹⁴ and care for the aged¹⁵ reflect God’s heart. **Jerusalem’s streets will be filled with wise older men and women given rightful status and the laughter of carefree children.** This represents restored peace and established righteousness—*shalom*—a theme repeated throughout the prophets.

Though these descriptions seem almost too good to be true, God Himself will accomplish everything He has promised. **Nothing is too difficult for God, though His assurances of restoration may seem more marvelous than we can comprehend.** God promises to regather His scattered people and bring them back to Jerusalem, where they will live as His people.

The People’s Responsibility (8:9-17) – The Lord Almighty called His people to strengthen their hands and rebuild the temple. He confirmed the messages given by the prophets when the temple foundations were laid. They were to live in light of all God had promised for their good and that of their city. Their commitment to God was not to consider Him as a mere encouraging concept or nice idea but to be led by God to a specific work. To Zechariah’s original audience, this meant moving forward with the temple’s reconstruction in Jerusalem. When God’s people align their hearts with His, following Him does not remain a vague concept. Believers seek to obey God in their values, priorities, and practices and in serving God in specific ways and settings He has prepared for them.¹⁶

These verses pick up Zechariah’s theme introduced in 7:8-10. God again reminded His people that wholehearted commitment to Him would impact the way they dealt with others. He directed them to speak truthfully to one another and render sound judgments in the courts. They were to reject evil plots against one another and refuse to swear falsely. Loving God and living for Him will impact personal relationships, business dealings, community interactions, and daily life. Mere external rituals or empty verbal declarations mean nothing. **A transformed heart yields a transformed life.**

10. God’s departing glory: Ezekiel 10:1-2, 18-19

11. Returning glory: Ezekiel 43:1-5

12. Holiness portrayed: Zechariah 14:20-21

13. Restoration in Israel: Romans 11:26-29

14. Preciousness of the young: Mark 10:13-16

15. Care for the aged: Isaiah 46:4

16. Serving God: Ephesians 2:10

Promises of Blessing – 8:18-23

From Fasts to Feasts (8:18-19) – Through Zechariah, the delegation from Bethel received God’s answer regarding continuing the ritual fasts established during the exile. Surely, they found God’s answer encouraging! **Fasts—times of mourning—would be turned into feasts—times of rejoicing.** Happy festivals would return to Judah, celebrating God’s faithfulness. God gave a command rising from His promise of coming joy: “Therefore love truth and peace.” God’s people not only believe truth, but they learn to love truth. God’s peace settles troubled hearts and provides a refuge where settled hearts love to find their rest.

From Curse to Blessing (8:20-23) – God promised people and joy will overflow on the city streets. **Jerusalem will become a place where people from many nations come to seek the Lord together with His people.** Instead of being a stumbling block to the nations, Israel will become such a blessing that 10 people will grab one Jew by the hem of his robe. Why this appeal from other peoples and nations? The gathering crowds explained, “Let us go with you, because we have heard that God is with you.”

God promised that His chosen people will bless the world.¹⁷ On a coming day, God will let His people experience all He has promised them. God’s people thrive when they live for Him. **God calls people out of empty religion into a vibrant relationship with Him.** Humbly seeking and trusting the Lord bring blessings the world cannot offer.

● Take to Heart

Hold Fast

God again spoke to and through Zechariah after his eight visions. **When a group from Bethel inquired about continuing scheduled fasts, God exposed their superficial religion and called them to seek Him sincerely.** Their religious gestures only served themselves; their hearts did not yearn for God. True heart change would lead to compassion for the weak and vulnerable, seeking truth, and promoting the good of others.

God also offered positive reasons for His people to seek Him wholeheartedly. **God desired their heartfelt devotion and promised He would again live among them and cause them to experience His blessings.** In a future day, people from around the world will stream to Jerusalem, seeking God’s wisdom and the joy experienced by His people. These amazing promises likely point to a coming time when Christ will return to establish His kingdom on earth. God’s certain promises give His people hope and comfort.

Apply It

True faith is neither ornamental nor mechanical. Too often, shrinking our responsibility before God into a measurable checklist appeals to us. We like controlling the what, when, and how of serving God. However, God hates plastic religion that fails to alter the way people think and live. Why is it so easy to go through the motions? What makes outward compliance matter more than the posture of your heart toward God? How does appearing righteous to others mask the mutiny in your heart?

17. Promise of blessing: Genesis 12:1-3

In what way might your service to God be more about you than Him? In so many ways, self-interest consumes us and invades every corner of our lives. Until we see Jesus face to face, we will never serve Him with entirely untainted motives. Yet, as we shed self-serving superficiality and allow God's Spirit to transform us, we grow in genuine love for others. We recognize God's worthiness and our insufficiency. We care about others and injustice in the world, extending help, mercy, and compassion to those around us. How did Zechariah's call to reality rather than ritual convict you specifically this week? How will you respond?

The Israelites fasted loudly and regularly for 70 years in exile. However, in response to God's blessing, the time had come for God's joy to permeate their thoughts and celebrations. God delights to turn mourning into joy. Many things in life draw us into a cycle of despair. Lingering questions, wayward children, difficult marriages, financial stress, prayers that seem unanswered, and many other challenges surround us in this sin-occupied world. **The joy God gives transcends circumstances.** Unlike happiness, joy comes from embracing God's promises and living within His truth—even amid unresolved issues. There is a time and there are reasons to mourn, certainly.¹⁸ But God offers peace and hope that we can see through the eyes of faith. We can rejoice even as we weep. We can pour out our prayers to God and trust Him to accomplish His greater purposes, even if we never fully see those solutions. Isaiah 61:3 promises God's people will experience "a crown of beauty instead of ashes, the oil of joy instead of mourning, a garment of praise instead of a spirit of despair. They will be called oaks of righteousness, a planting of the LORD to display His splendor." How will you allow God's joy to transcend your heaviest burden today?

People from many nations will seek the joyous environment and spiritual understanding God's people will experience in the restored Jerusalem—which sounds wonderful. However, our world differs greatly from the environment described in Zechariah 8. **What helps Christ's presence, power, and peace to so radiate through you that others notice?** Do your neighbors and coworkers perceive the way you process stress, face obstacles, care for others, and experience joy? People who live for the Lord walk out of step with the world but manifest a presence that unbelievers often find intriguing. Has someone you know asked you to pray for them? Do people recognize that God is with you? When our love and commitment to the Lord is more than a mechanical exercise, we live differently. People who genuinely seek God love truth, pursue peace, overcome fear, and prioritize the good of others. And people notice. How is God's transforming power evident in you?

18. Time to mourn: Ecclesiastes 3:1-4

Answers

1. Answers will vary.
2. Answers will vary.
3. The events and messages recorded in Zechariah 7 (the fourth year of King Darius) occurred two years after the first message recorded in Zechariah 1 (the second year of King Darius) and two years before the temple construction was completed (the sixth year of King Darius, according to Ezra 6:15). The prophets Haggai and Zechariah spoke God's message to move forward the stalled reconstruction efforts (Ezra 5:1-2, 16). *Note for TLs:* Remind your GLs of the Exile and Return Timeline in the Resource Library or their lesson book for historical context.
4.
 - a. Two appointed delegates, Sharezer and Regem-Melek, and their men came to inquire of Israel's priests and prophets. They asked whether they should continue to mourn and fast in the fifth month, as they had done for many years (during the exile, along with other fasts).
 - b. The word from the Lord did not answer their question but instead asked all the people another question. God questioned the intent and motives behind their fasts and feasts. Did they fast for the Lord or for themselves?
5.
 - a. Answers will vary. Plagued with an inborn sinful nature and self-centered desires, we often seek a system of worship or calculated obedience that gives us a sense of control. Spiritual disciplines and religious observances have merit when our hearts truly seek God. However, when we equate pleasing God with rituals that become mechanical performance, our efforts may be more about stroking our pride than serving and pleasing God. Sin has a way of distorting even what God intends to be good.
 - b. Answers will vary.
6.
 - a. These verses offer two positive commands: (1) administer true justice and (2) show mercy and compassion to one another. There are also two negative commands: (1) do not oppress the widow or the fatherless, the foreigner, or the poor and (2) do not plot evil against one another.
 - b. God's response to the question posed to Zechariah exhorted the people to seek God purely and from the heart. Wholehearted consecration to God produces righteousness and compassion that mirrors God's heart and extends to others. James 1:27 describes pure and faultless religion that honors God: looking after widows and orphans and keeping oneself unpolluted by the world.
 - c. Answers will vary. Those with power and position corrupted by evil often prey on the weak and oppress the vulnerable. To care genuinely for those without resources of their own reflects God's heart of compassion and His willing sacrifice for the sake of others.
7.
 - a. God's people had refused to pay attention, stubbornly turning their backs on God and covering their ears, shutting out His commands and warnings. They made their hearts as hard as flint and would not listen to the Lord's words given by His Spirit to His prophets.

- b. Their persistent resistance made the Lord Almighty very angry. When He called and they refused to listen, He scattered them among the nations, as if with a whirlwind. He left their land desolate.
8. Answers will vary.
9. God declared He was “very jealous for Zion ... burning with jealousy for her,” declarations we also see in Nahum 1:2 and Zechariah 1:14-15. These words communicate a very strong response, though God’s perfection and utter righteousness make His response completely different than human jealousy. The words used here also communicate His lack of tolerance for Israel’s enemies and His fervent desire for the nation’s wholehearted consecration as His people.
10. In verses 3-4, God promised He would return to Zion, that Jerusalem would be called “the Faithful City,” and that the mountain of the Lord would be known as “the Holy Mountain.” Verses 4-5 speak of a thriving city characterized by safety and security, where the aged are afforded appropriate respect and the boys and girls granted carefree childhoods. Verse 6 confirms that though these assurances seem almost too marvelous, God will accomplish what He promises. Verses 7-8 speak of the return of the scattered Israelites to live in Jerusalem as God’s people under His faithful and righteous care. Verses 9-13 foretell of a safe environment for business and fruitful, prospering agriculture. God would save His people and make them a blessing. Verses 14-15 promise God’s favor would again rest upon Judah and Jerusalem, rather than the disaster they had faced in their past.
11. As the returned exiles labored to rebuild the temple and restore Jerusalem, God’s promises of His returned favor and blessing would encourage them. Their 70 long years in exile were difficult, but better days lay ahead.
12.
 - a. In Genesis 12:1-3, God promised to bless Abraham and make a great nation from his descendants. That nation would bless the world, especially through Messiah—Jesus Christ, the Savior God promised. These verses record specific blessings in store for God’s people as well as God’s plan for them to bless other peoples.
 - b. Answers will vary.
13. Verse 17 tells us the Lord hates it when people plot evil against one another and swear falsely. In verse 16, He calls His people to show genuine love to others, speaking truth and rendering true and sound judgments in the courts. Verse 19 commands God’s people to love truth and peace.
14.
 - a. In answer to the delegation’s question about continuing the fasts they began while in exile, God promised that the series of fasts will be transformed into joyous feasts, celebrating God’s blessing upon Judah.
 - b. People weighed down with the burdens of sin and life in a fallen world find hope and help from the Lord. Isaiah 61:1-3 speaks of God transforming sorrow and weeping into joy and praise, and 2 Corinthians 4:17-18 promises that the light and momentary affliction believers suffer in this life will be exchanged for an eternal glory that far outweighs the sorrow and pain they suffered. Therefore, believers should fix their eyes on unseen realities rather than the temporary world they can see.
 - c. Answers will vary. Recognizing God’s purposeful work, sanctifying power, and sustaining grace offers hope and brings joy even through life’s greatest challenges.

15. People from the world's nations will want to travel to Jerusalem to seek the Lord Almighty. People from all languages will recognize the blessings of God's people, with 10 people firmly taking hold of the robe of one Jewish person, signifying the nations' desire to associate with the people of Israel, recognizing God is with His people.
16. Answers will vary.

Teaching Leaders and [Distance] Online Trainers: Refer to the Homiletics section in the Leadership Development Tool Kit for sample training on homiletics.

Divisions:

- I. God answers a question about fasting with a call to serve Him and others. (Zechariah 7)
- II. God promises a bright future for Jerusalem and Israel. (Zechariah 8)

Subject sentence: Zechariah's answer about fasting reveals God's purposes for His people.

Aim: God calls people out of empty religion into a vibrant relationship with Him.

Applications:

1. In what ways might self-interest motivate your efforts to serve God?
2. How has God turned mourning into joy or ritual into reality in your life?

Doctrine: Millennium

Principles:

Truly pleasing God means loving Him and serving others.

God's presence and power work for the good of His people.

Doctrine Resource

This resource helps you prepare a doctrine talk that magnifies God and matures His people.

Remember to:

- Focus on the doctrine by adding key points of relevant doctrine from the *TL Manual* or other resources.
- Conclude with encouraging applications for your leaders demonstrating why this doctrine matters.

Lesson 20

Text: Zechariah 7–8

Doctrine: Millennium

Bridge to Doctrine: Through the prophet Zechariah, God encouraged His people with prophecies regarding their promising future and that of Jerusalem, which will flourish. These prophecies likely point to the time of Christ's future reign on earth, known as "the millennium."

Key Points and Insertion of Doctrine into Passage:

Zechariah 8

- The concept of the millennium emerges most clearly from Revelation 20 and is supported by many prophecies foretelling Christ's unrivaled reign on earth.
- Sincere Christians hold varying views on the millennium.
- The differing opinions regarding the millennium are centered on the timing of Christ's earthly rule and whether biblical promises should be seen as spiritual realities or interpreted literally and physically.
- Bible Study Fellowship graciously supports a premillennial view but recognizes that people interpret these prophecies differently. The premillennial view holds that Christ will reign for one thousand years, bind Satan, and establish His kingdom on earth.
- Ultimately, God wants His people to face the future with hope, knowing He will return to earth and restore what sin has corrupted. When Christ reigns, people will experience profound joy and peace.
- When I do not believe that Christ will reign on earth in the millennium, the world around me seems a dismal place without hope of restoration. The apparent stronghold of God's enemies seems to render the Bible's promises distant and removed from what I experience today. Fear and uncertainty lead to self-preservation and corruption.
- When I believe that Christ's millennial reign will bring the beautiful environment God has promised, I recognize that God's purposes for history move forward as He plans and determines. God's promises about the future give me confidence for today and as I face the future trusting God.

Possible Applications for Leaders:

The following concepts can be developed into applications specific to *your* leaders:

- The strife and chaos in the world cause us to long for Christ to reign without rival.
 - As you look at the world today, who seems to be in control? Who is really in control?
 - Believers find comfort in knowing that what they witness today is not the end of God's story.
 - How does the truth of Christ's future reign on earth help you process our world today?
- Christ rules now in the hearts of His people but will one day return physically to reign on earth.
 - Christ's authority and sovereignty are not on hold awaiting a future day but are active and in motion today.
 - In what ways have you experienced the peace and joy of Christ ruling your heart and life?
 - What helps you live in the reality of Christ's future reign despite the opposition to God and His rule all around us?
- The certainty of Christ's reign matters more than our limited understanding of the details.
 - Our struggle over what we cannot understand should not limit our confidence in what we do understand.
 - How will you trust what God has revealed about His future reign and also what seems less clear?
 - God's certain promises hold His people secure. How will you trust God today?

Men's Talking Points

Overview

Purpose: Identify unique points from this passage for men to discuss and apply to their lives.

Zechariah 7–8 challenges men to be sincere in their devotion to God.

Doctrine: The millennium

Aim: God calls people out of empty religion into a vibrant relationship with Him.

Talking Points

Truth: A man of faith is sincere (Zechariah 7:4-6). / *Lie: Fake it until you make it.*

- **Lie:** The world is a stage, allowing anyone to act like the kind of person they wish to portray. Hiding their true desires, men of the world read the room and adjust their mannerisms accordingly. This cowardly hypocrisy includes going through the motions to meet external expectations without personal conviction or heart transformation.
- **Truth:** A man of faith is boldly and humbly authentic. Knowing he is a repentant sinner saved only by God's grace, he confesses quickly, turns away from sin, and lives in the freedom of God's redemption. His joy and devotion are sincere because he knows he is loved by God and lives as a genuine vessel sharing God's love to the world.
- **Application:** What in your life is a hypocritical "act" that hides your sin? What do you need to surrender to God so you can live in the freedom of sincere expression of your faith?

Truth: A man of faith is kind and compassionate (Zechariah 7:8-10). / *Lie: The end justifies the means.*

- **Lie:** A man of the world believes he has the power and right to be devious and oppressive to accomplish his own agenda. Others' needs or suffering are not his concern. They are simply a factor to overcome when getting and staying ahead of everyone else.
- **Truth:** A man of faith empathizes deeply with the fallen world. The pain and suffering of this world wound and grieve him, just as they break his Savior's heart. Like Jesus, a man of God cares and weeps for the broken. Led by the Holy Spirit, a godly man seeks to do what he can to bring salt, light, healing, and hope to the suffering.
- **Application:** What actions do you take in response to the pain and suffering you see? What lies or wounds might you be harboring that keep you from showing and practicing compassion toward others?

Truth: A man of faith listens to God (Zechariah 7:13). / *Lie: Listen to your heart and follow your desires.*

- **Lie:** A man of the world believes he is king of his domain. While he might tap into self-help books or even the Bible, he ultimately follows his own whims, feelings, and ambition. Accountable to no one, he defies God and does not yield to Him. He sees God as an impediment to his selfish desires.
- **Truth:** A man of faith cares about what God thinks and listens to what He says. He is dedicated to listening to God through His Word, in prayer, and through the community of fellow believers. He knows God's ways are higher and better than his ways and God's thoughts are infinitely wiser than his own. Therefore, he chooses to live a fruitful, God-honoring life, serving others.
- **Application:** Whose voice is the primary one you listen to and follow? God's? Your own? Someone else's? How much time and effort do you invest in listening to God? How do you respond when God's direction becomes clearer through your time with Him?

Lesson 20: Zechariah 7-8

Rajesh Gogu

Strategic Framework

Zechariah 7-8 / Lesson 20

Doctrine: Millennium

Aim: CATL that seeking the Lord relationally results in restoration.

I. Seeking the Lord through Religious Works (Ch. 7)

- A. Religion focuses on works (7:1-3)
- B. Religion satisfies self (7:4-7)
- C. Religion lacks love (7:8-12)
- D. Religion results in despair (7:13-14)

Principle: God gives repentant hearts the desire to worship Him and serve others.

II. Seeking the Lord through Relationship (Ch. 8)

- A. The Lord seeks people (8:1-6)
 - Doctrine vv. 3-5
- B. The Lord saves people (8:7-13)
- C. The Lord sanctifies people (8:14-17)
- D. The Lord satisfies people (8:18-23)

Doctrine vv. 19, 21-23

Principle: A heart restored by God's love inspires others to have a genuine relationship with Him.

COACHING COMMENTS

A strength modeled by the lecturer is sprinkling applications throughout the lecture. This effective technique enables the audience to gradually absorb the lessons of the passage. While applications are expected after each principle, there are lessons to learn throughout the passage, and highlighting those in small doses helps the listeners take them in.

The lecturer also stayed focused on the aim from start to finish. Pulling the thread of the aim through the lecture helps the audience see how each part of the lecture supports the aim. A steady focus on the aim also increases the chance that the listeners will remember the main truth of the entire passage.

This is the lecture for Lesson 20 of the BSF study "People of the Promise, Exile and Return".

"If you don't work hard and study well, you will be raising buffalos!" Growing up, that was a common phrase in many homes in our region. Unfortunately for many, their honor was tied to how they or their children perform in academics or professionally. So there was always a great emphasis on work and performance. I can't blame any parent for high expectations because in the current world, competition is cutthroat. Resumes must showcase one's ability to do an exceptional job under pressure. "Perform or perish" seems to be the corporate mantra.

Religion is no exception. All the religions in the world ask devotees to come with a report card of religious works. Based on their performance, they are either accepted or rejected. Sadly, there seems to be no option but to perform.

But what a contrast we see in Zechariah Chapters 7 and 8. As we study these two chapters, we will see how the world and its systems encourage us to seek the Lord through works, whereas the Gospel invites us to seek the Lord through a relationship. Understanding this will lift a heavy burden off our shoulders. We will be restored when we seek Him for who He is and long to have a relationship with Him. Seeking the Lord relationally results in restoration. How radical, liberating, and refreshing is this message!

Seeking the Lord relationally results in restoration. We'll unpack this idea in two sections. From Chapter 7, Seeking the Lord Through Religious Works and what's the result of this approach. From Chapter 8, Seeking the Lord Through a Relationship and where that will lead us.

Let's begin with Seeking the Lord Through Religious Works in Chapter 7. In verses 1 through 3, we see how religion focuses on works. In Chapter 1, Zechariah received the word of the Lord during the second year of King Darius. When Zechariah wrote Chapter 7, two years had passed since he had heard from God, and the temple reconstruction was progressing well. People thought that they were on the path of restoration. The days of weeping and fasting were behind them, and the time of feasting was ahead.

So the people of Bethel sent a delegation to Jerusalem to inquire about the fasts. They had been fasting and weeping in memory of the fall of Solomon's temple for the last 70 years. Should they continue to observe the fast? Their question seemed reasonable. They had fasted for the destroyed temple; and now, it was nearly restored, so why continue fasting?

On the surface, the question seemed genuine, but the Lord's response reveals it was anything but sincere. Firstly, He had never commanded them to fast during those months. It was a man-made tradition. Secondly, if their fasting had been genuine, they wouldn't have asked the question. At its core, their fast was not an act of worship but a religious ritual. They no longer had genuine grief or repentance over the temple's destruction due to their disobedience; only relief that their long-endured fasts were finally over. Religion always focuses on works, not on relationship.

If we examine our hearts and probe into the real motives behind what we do, we will realize that we are exactly like the delegation from Bethel. But why are we wired this way? Why do we seek to follow rituals rather than a relationship with the Lord? If we think about it, the rituals we do are tangible, just like the credentials in our resumes. We flash them before God and others and demand acceptance for our performance. Our works brings us praise and a false sense of security. No wonder all religions focus on works and place man at the center of it. So let me ask what works are we bringing before God today and exhibiting him to bless us?

Secondly, we see from verses 4 through 7 that religion satisfies self. Instead of responding to their inquiry, the Lord cross-examines their motives through two questions. The first question is about

their fasting. "When you have fasted and mourned all these years, was it really for me?" The second question is about their feasting. "When you ate and drank, weren't you doing it for yourself?"

They were putting on a show that they cared about the temple. Religion focuses on what our eyes can see. There is little or no attention to deeper realities. If they had checked their motives by questioning "Why?", they would have realized that they did not heed the warnings to repent. Their sins had resulted in a broken relationship with God and the destruction of the temple. They were blinded to this spiritual reality.

Instead of seeking to restore their relationship with God through wholehearted repentance, they resorted to things their hands could do. Religion always focuses on external rituals while ignoring the importance of heart transformation. So their fasts and feasts became a facade of their religiosity. They seemed like they genuinely cared for their relationship with the Lord. But in reality, their hearts were far from God. They were promoting and worshiping themselves through their fasts. There was no repentance in their innermost being.

Nothing is hidden from the all-knowing God. He knew their motives and how selfish they were. Time and again in His grace, He exposed their self-centeredness and duplicity. So let me ask why are we coming to BSF? What is our real motive? Is it because this is what all good Christians do? Is it to satisfy our religious hunger? Or is it really to know and seek the Lord? Let's pause and check our motives behind why we do what we do.

Thirdly, we see that religion lacks love from verses 8 through 12. Their focus had been external religious works. But what they should have focused on was works of justice and compassion for the marginalized. This can mislead us if we are not careful. The Lord was not pleased with their religious works; but here, it seems like He is promoting works.

In reality, the Lord was exposing their duplicity and self-love. If they really sought the Lord with all their heart, it would have resulted in genuine service for others. They were satisfying themselves without serving the weakest in society. James Chapter 1 says, "Religion that God our Father accepts as pure and faultless is this: to look after orphans and widows in their distress." Genuine faith results in genuine works. Here, the Lord was showing them the condition of their faith through their works. Their self-love reveals that there was no genuine faith. Their religion was flawed and lacked love.

Time and again, they refused to pay attention to God's diagnosis. They chose to give God a cold shoulder, deaf ears, and a dead heart. If their religion was true, they would have loved God and showed that by loving and serving their neighbors.

It's easy to talk about how selfish those people were. But the truth is that we are no different. Often the work we do for God blinds us to others. We claim we are serving the Lord, but we are really loving and serving our own interests without compassion for others. Our love towards God must result in genuine service to others.

What's the point of spending hours in the Word of God but not showing compassion to those at our workplace? What is the point of studying the Scriptures but not taking a stand for the weak and marginalized? Religion lacks love; whereas, a person touched by the Gospel repents and responds in love. Let's ask ourselves, what do our religious works say about our love for God and service to others?

We saw that religion focuses on works, satisfies self, lacks love; and lastly, we see religion results in despair from verses 13 to 14. God constantly warned His people to repent and seek Him. Time and again, He showed them that He delights in obedience rather than religious sacrifices. Yet they preferred religious works over a relationship with Him, leading to three consequences: God refused to

listen to their cries, scattered them among the nations, and left their promised land desolate. The story of the fall in Eden repeats itself. In the Garden, humanity chose to worship itself rather than worshiping and seeking a relationship with God. As a result, they were banished from paradise. Despair became humanity's address.

The bottom line is this: Religion without a relationship with God results in despair. But here is the good news. When we repent and ask the Lord to forgive us, He forgives us and gives us a heart that sincerely longs to worship Him and serve others. As we conclude this chapter, here is our first principle: God gives repentant hearts, desire to worship Him and serve others.

Principle: God gives repentant hearts, desire to worship and serve others.

We are created to have a relationship with our Creator and worship Him for who He is. But in our sin, we often worship ourselves. Even our good deeds are about ourselves and we fail to love genuinely. In light of this passage, let's examine the motives behind our actions. If He is exposing self-centeredness in our hearts, may we repent for seeking Him through religious works. We must also reflect on what our service reveals about our true object of worship.

If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just and will forgive us our sins and purify us from all unrighteousness. If we think we are not sinning, we are fooling ourselves. Often we approach Him with our works and through them, we seek to worship Him. Today, the call is to repent from this sin. God gives repentant hearts, the desire to worship Him and serve others.

So far, we saw Seeking the Lord Through Religious Works and what was the result of that approach. Now let's unpack the theme of Seeking the Lord Through Relationship in Chapter 8. This section stands in stark contrast to Chapter 7. The first thing we notice in Chapter 8 from verses 1 to 6 is that the Lord seeks His people.

Look at verse 2 of Chapter 8. The Lord Almighty says: "I am very jealous for Zion; I am burning with jealousy for her." The Lord Almighty is the most dominant phrase in these two chapters with 18 repetitions in Chapter 8. The Lord who created and holds the entire universe in His hands, the Lord who is sovereign, all-powerful and all-knowing, the Lord at whose words darkness runs for cover, mountains flee, the Lord who is complete in Himself and lacks nothing or desires nothing, longs to have a relationship with His creation.

Doesn't this amaze us? It's beyond our comprehension; isn't it? Verse 2 says that He is burning with passion for His people. This is not like the romantic love we celebrate in popular culture. His love is completely pure.

He is jealous for us. Again, this jealousy is not like ours. His jealousy is holy and righteous. We can understand God's jealousy in two ways here. His love overflows toward us and passionately judges those who come against Him and His beloved.

This is what we see in the Garden of Eden. As soon as Adam and Eve sinned, God came and declared His love and commitment towards humanity by promising a Savior who would restore our broken relationship. But at the same time, He declared His righteous anger and judgment toward the devil who tried to snatch and destroy His beloved.

The people of Bethel came to Him with their religious works, expecting God to restore the relationship based on their religious works. To their surprise, God was telling them, "You cannot seek me sincerely, but I will seek you."

What a contrast we see in the Gospel. The Son of God came to seek and save the lost. He is committed in this relationship towards us. This should humble and inspire us to respond to His love

relationally. Let me ask you how do we respond to the truth that the Son of God is committed to seek us and live with us?

Not only is He going to seek His people, but He will also return and dwell in Jerusalem. What comforting words these must be for His people. The glory of the Lord had left the temple; but now, He was making a commitment to return and dwell there again. He will not only restore the broken relationship but also restore the city. Jerusalem, which was known for its unfaithfulness, will be called a faithful city and the holy mountain of the Lord.

Partially, this was fulfilled through Jesus's incarnation. The Word of God, Jesus, came and dwelt among us; and John says we have seen His glory. But Zechariah predicts that the Lord Almighty will return and dwell permanently with His people. Revelation Chapters 19 through 22 describes this time period we understand to be a 1,000-year physical reign of the Lord Jesus Christ as King over the entire earth at the very end of this period of human history often known as millennium, which in Latin means "thousand years".

Think about this: Humanity longs to live life in its fullest potential, give our best, and showcase our creative talents. We all hope for a world overflowing with joy, peace, beauty, and unity amongst humanity. No wonder artists, writers, and film makers create worlds that capture the themes our souls yearn for. During the millennial reign of Christ, such a world will be a reality. The Lord, through Zechariah, from verse 4 onwards, gives us glimpse of His rule. He will certainly do it. We can trust the promises He attests with, "This is what the Lord Almighty says," or even challenges us, "Will it seem marvelous to me?"

When we believe that Christ's rule will bring such a world, the brokenness around us does not lead to cynicism. Instead, we experience, peace, hope, and anticipation as we cry, "Come, Lord Jesus." We trust that God will fulfill our deepest longings. Without this belief, we have no hope for the world, and our longings may feel like mere beautiful illusions.

In verses 4 through 5, Zechariah gives us a picture of how the millennium is going to be. Jerusalem will be filled with elderly people and children will roam the streets freely, symbolizing that people will have long lives and there will be safety and security. Isaiah 61 gives us more details. Never again will an infant live for just a few days or someone dying at a hundred years be considered cursed. In the millennium rule of Jesus, life will flourish and there will be peace and security. For me, this is exciting as today, I can't even let my children go to the neighborhood park on their own.

This is how the Lord plans to restore His broken relationship with humanity -- by coming to dwell among us and reigning such that life thrives. For the Israelites running from exile and rebuilding their lives, such promises may have seemed too good to be true. That's why, in verse 6, the Lord reassures them: "It may seem marvelous to the remnant of this people at that time, but will it seem marvelous to me?" It's as if God is saying, "One day, I will demonstrate my power and show what I can do. When I decide to act, who can stop me?" A vision of streets filled with joyful children and the elderly is no big deal -- it's child's play for Him.

There is nothing more beautiful and awe-inspiring than the Creator of the universe seeking a relationship with His creation. The more we ponder over this truth, the more we will seek Him with fervent love and not works.

Secondly from verses 7 through 13, the Lord saves His people. From verses 7 through 8, we see that the Lord promises to save His people from their enemies, bringing them back from all corners of the world, and establish them in Jerusalem. They will be His people and He will be their God. These are words of assurance and comfort given to the people who came back from exile. He will not only seek

them with great fervor, but He will also save them. In no other religion do we see such a commitment from a human, let alone from a God.

Here is the marvel of the gospel: 2,000 years ago, God sent His Son into the world. In humility, Jesus faced humanity's greatest enemies -- sin and death -- and defeated them through His sacrifice. His passionate love and zeal to save were revealed on the cross. Now, because of Jesus, humanity can live in peace with God. The promise given in the Garden was fulfilled at Calvary. He delights to save us. Fulfilled promises instill confidence in future promises, such as the millennial reign of Christ.

In verses 9 through 11, God promises to deal with them not according to what they deserve. So He encourages them to continue to rebuild the temple with confidence. Verse 11 declares, "I will not deal with the remnant of this people as I did in the past," says the Lord Almighty. From this side of the cross, we see its fullness: God did not deal with us according to our sins but showed grace by sending His Son. Instead of condemnation, we have received acceptance and eternal glory through Him.

So let me ask in light of this truth, how are we building His temple, the church? Work done in gratitude pleases God more than religious rituals.

In verses 12 to 13, we continue to see what else the Lord will restore. In verse 3, He promised to restore the city to be a faithful city. In verse 12, He promises to restore the land, making it fruitful; and in verse 13, He promises to restore the people by taking away the curse and making them a blessing. They will be fruitful and faithful people of God. God is committed to restoring their identity as His people.

Religion puts the onus on the people. You do good works, you go on pilgrimages, you do this or that. But after doing all that, it does not guarantee restoration. What a contrast we see in the Gospel. God is committed to seeking and saving us. He sent His Son to restore our relationship with Him and build His kingdom. Instead of dealing with us according to our sins, He extended grace through Jesus, reversing sin's curse. Now, through the Spirit, we bear fruit and live as God's children -- "a holy nation and royal priesthood "

We must be most pitied if these truths are not moving and changing our hearts. We all long to be loved. Here is a God who is revealing how much He loves us. If this does not inspire us to seek Him, I don't know what else can. So let me ask how are you responding to God's love? God's commitment to love and save us is our motivation to love Him and love our neighbors.

Thirdly from verses 14 through 17, we see the Lord sanctifies His people. The Israelites were exiled to Babylon for 70 years because of their persistent sin. God knew that their works will never restore them back to Him. So in His love, He comforts them saying, "I dealt harshly with you, but the days are coming I will not deal with you like the way I dealt with you earlier. I have resolved to do good again to Jerusalem and Judah." He comforts them with words of promise and dispels their fear.

After restoring our relationship, God expects good works as a response to salvation, not the other way around. In verses 16 to 17, He calls them to shine His light through actions like spreading the truth, practicing sound judgment, avoiding evil, and refraining from falsehood.

Religion thrives on works and fear of God's anger. No wonder people engage in rituals -- lining up at temples, taking holy dips, going on pilgrimages, making sacrifices, and performing good deeds -- to appease the gods. "Sanctify yourself" is the religion's demands, placing a heavy burden on people, with dutiful obedience at its core.

Once again, we see a sharp contrast. God loved us so much that He gave His Son to save us. His commitment to our eternal good is unwavering. If you doubt His love, look to the cross. Be comforted

by His love and find freedom in His salvation. As we surrender to Him, He sanctifies us to be more like Jesus by transforming us inside out. Transformed by His love, we respond with delightful obedience, and serving God and others becomes a joy.

How are these truths dispelling our fear and inspiring us to seek God to perfect us like Jesus? The more we become like Jesus, the more we can love others.

We saw how the Lord seeks, saves, sanctifies, and lastly from verses 18 through 23, we see that the Lord satisfies His people. Zechariah predicts that in the future, the nation Israel will repent and return to God, fulfilling the first commandment in letter and in spirit. The Lord gives a picture of how those days are going to be. The days of the millennium will be marked with unending celebration.

Rebuilding the temple and looking forward to a feast is great, but the Lord is building a greater temple in Jesus. He will come and dwell in His glory with His people. Under His sovereign and righteous rule, all fasts will cease. There will be unending joy and cheerful feasts. The Lord will satisfy His people. Considering this greater future reality, we grow to love both truth and peace.

We see further details of the millennium in verses 20 through 22. People from many cities and nations come together not to fight or make a name like they did at Babel, but they come together and encourage each other to seek the Lord. Look at these beautiful words in verse 21: "Let us go at once to entreat the LORD and seek the LORD Almighty. I myself am going. And many peoples and powerful nations will come to Jerusalem to seek the LORD Almighty and to entreat him." The word "entreat" reflects desire to worship and serve the Lord. Don't we all await that day? We will truly find our satisfaction in seeking the Lord.

One final picture of the millennium is given in verse 23, how the nations are going to seek the Lord. People from every tribe, nation and tongue will tightly grab the robe of a Jew, saying, "Let us go with you for we have heard that God is with you." "The nations will be blessed through Abraham" was the promise given and it will find its ultimate fulfillment in the millennium. Everything in the Bible will be fulfilled. Only one person can orchestrate all this -- our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. And He will surely do it.

In the millennium, God's people will perfectly live out their lives' calling; loving God with their being and reflecting His light to those around them. Those who understand this will not wait for the millennium but will live out their calling today. Loving God and shining His glory. When we do this with a repentant and sincere heart, we become attractive to those around us. That's what's happening in this chapter. That brings us to our second principle: A heart restored by God's love inspires others to have a genuine relationship with Him.

Principle: A heart restored by God's love inspires others to have a genuine relationship with Him.

The Lord Almighty passionately sought and saved us, sanctifies us with His Word, and will one day satisfy our deepest longings. How do we respond to His love? Do we approach Him with our resumes or with repentance, surrender and worship? When restored hearts respond to His love, it becomes so attractive that others are drawn, asking, "Who is this Lord you are serving? Can we come and see Him? Can we have a relationship with Him, too?" How marvelous that would be! Isn't that our calling today? Our restored relationship with God is powerfully attractive to the watching world. Let us not underestimate the power of a restored relationship with our Lord and Savior Jesus.

Religions only promote pointless religious works. Only Jesus Christ shows us that He created us to have a relationship with Him. He is committed to this relationship and will do everything to restore this relationship to what He intended it to be. No wonder then that for every statement He makes in these two chapters, He puts His seal by saying, "The Lord Almighty says this". How do you respond to

what the Lord Almighty is saying to you today? Will you still pursue works or a relationship with Him?
Let me pray.

Fasting and Feasting

Zechariah 7–8

There is a unifying principle in chapters 7 and 8. Here Zechariah expresses the need for the people to walk in a proper manner before the Lord, realizing the hope of a bright, promise-fulfilled future while remembering the consequences of their past that lead to judgment.

The Question – Zechariah 7:1-3

The Setting – 7:1

Almost two years after the series of his night visions (1:7–6:8), the people brought a question to the prophet.

The Inquiry – 7:2-3

A delegation from Bethel, a town north of Jerusalem, came to the temple with a question. Since the exile was over, should they continue the fasts conducted during the exile, longing and pleading for the rebuilding of the temple?

The Reply – Zechariah 7:4–8:23

The Rebuke of Ritualism – 7:4-7

The word of the Lord came to Zechariah, who asked a question in return: Were they fasting and feasting for the Lord or as a religious formality of self-centeredness?

The Question of Motive Behind Religious Activity – 7:4-5

Their question revealed a greater issue— the true motivation the people of Bethel.

The prophet delivered a strong condemnation by asking questions that went beyond a yes or no answer. Zechariah struck at their motive for fasting during the exile. Did they fast for the Lord or as a religious formality based on self-centeredness?

The Issue of Motive for Life in General – 7:6-7

Zechariah turned to the behavior of the people before the exile, the cause of the exile, and their conduct during it. The predominate issue was not that religious observance was neglected but that

the people's hearts were not in it. Religious ritual without a proper motive is abhorrent. Selfishness characterized the people in the past and the present! Instead of self-denial in fasting, there was self-indulgence.

The Exhortation to Valid Expressions of Devotion – 7:8-14

The Command – 7:8-10

What the Lord desires from His people is covenantal faithfulness, not mere external conformity without heart devotion. External conduct alone is insufficient. "They will know we are Christians by our love" captures the point. External devotion without internal devotion is false piety.

The Past Disobedience – 7:11-12

The people had refused to pay attention to the four commands of the Lord given in verses 9-10, turning their hearts into calloused "flint." With hardened hearts lacking true affection for God, they had stuffed their ears and would not listen to the prophets sent to them.

The Past Result – 7:13-14

Consequently, they experienced horrible consequences (destruction, death, and exile), the fruition promised for covenantal neglect. The land that once was beautiful became desolate.

The Restoration of Israel – 8:1-17

The Future Restoration (Encouragement to the Returnees) – 8:1-8

The Reason for Restoration – 8:1-2

Despite covenantal heartlessness, God's great love for His people, rooted in *His* covenantal commitment, will not cause them to be set aside forever. God longs for the day that He will bring His promises to fruition.

The Return of Messiah – 8:3a

When the prophet uttered these words, little did the people understand about their fulfillment. God will return to His people and dwell among them as the true and eternal temple (the presence of God).

The Results of Restoration – 8:3b-6

THE DESCRIPTION RENDERED – 8:3B-5

A vibrant city, then silenced by destruction, will once more come to life with the sounds of children playing.

THE QUESTION POSED – 8:6

For the doubters of God's promises, the people were asked to think about God's power. Is anything too difficult for God?

The Promise of Restoration 8:7-8

While a remnant of the people was in the land, the prophet was speaking of another day in the future. There will be a greater return yet to come. At that time, the people will worship God in heart expressed in righteous behavior, not heartless ritual.

The Present Encouragement – 8:9-17

The application of the prophet's message seems to strengthen him and the people who were undertaking the reconstruction of the temple. Zechariah was told that spiritual renewal must precede moral renewal; the latter is no substitute for the former.

The Reason for Discouragement – 8:10

Here was a motivation: the people were to think about the days of ritual without heart. What were they like (interpersonal descension, lack of peace, conflict)?

The Details of the Encouragement – 8:11-15

A wonderful day is ahead for the people of God; there will be peace and prosperity once more. This is coming a day when God will relent of His anger. "Do not be afraid" is a call to faith and trust.

The Commands to the Encouraged – 8:16-17

Simply put, they are asked to repent of the past, not duplicate it, and live in hope in the present.

The Restoration of Blessings – 8:18-23

Fasts Will Be Replaced with Festivals – 8:18-19

In a day to come, the grudging fasts of the past will become delightful, peace, joyful feasts. When the heart is into what we pursue, we experience joy! Love is the foundation of covenant duties, making them a delight.

The People Will Become a Sought-After Model of Religious Wisdom – 8:20-22

"Jerusalem" will become the center of God's dealing with people from all the nations because it will be seen as the dwelling place of God.

The People Will Then Lead the Nations to a Knowledge of God – 8:23

The reason is "we have heard that God is with you."

Teaching Points

- The difference between empty religious duties and true religious duties is not in the doing but in the motivation for the doing. If action is not rooted in a God-ward motive to please God first, then doing counts for nothing. We are not to obey to please God; we do what we do in heartfelt thankfulness that pleases God because of His covenant mercies. He allows us to be His people through the forgiveness of the prohibitive obstacle of our sin. Fruit is a function of the root; the root is the grace of God, resulting in appreciative obedience.

- Legalism is not the diligent pursuit of rules that we believe please God. Legalism is an attitude that the rules themselves cause God's pleasures, benevolences, and mercies toward us. Legalism is the belief that duty obligates God to us. Our humble duty to obey God comes from recognition of His mercies, flowing from the foundation of a thankful heart for God's grace received. We are not legalists; we are rule-followers because we stand in awe of His presence among us, not to acquire His pleasure or keep it!
- The question raised in 8:6 is worth a pause: "It may seem marvelous to the remnant of this people at that time, but will it seem marvelous to me?" Mary raised the same issue when told that she would bear a son in her virgin state. Gabriel replied, "For no word from God will ever fail" (Luke 1:37). Is there a "mountain" that you think is too high for you to cross? Is there a relationship that you think cannot be healed? Do you have a fear or memory that is just too much for you to carry and you are tormented? Is anything too difficult for the God who redeemed your soul? Ask him to help you!!
- We must not forget that we are a people in exile in that we have been delivered from the kingdom of darkness into the kingdom of God's son. We live in a place where the best and most beautiful things of earth will greatly fade when our exile is over forever and we are in the arms of Jesus. How might that motivate us to care for those around us, so that they too will enter a more beautiful world someday?
- It is an intriguing thought that the nations in a future day will seek out the wisdom of the true remnant of Israel (8:23). This represents a stark contrast to the treatment of Israel by most nations today. It is, in part, because they are not shining forth God's beauty in their rejection of the One who came for them only to be denounced by them. When the nations seek the wisdom of God's people, it will be because they possess His beauty, and that is attractive. The question for us is this: Are we, in our daily lives, exuding the invisible beauty of God so as to cause inquiry?
- I find that when it comes to details of the great final judgment and God's great eternal kingdom, the structure and chronology of future events baffles my little mind. I have this opinion, not because I think the Bible is in error, but because the various ways of charting the end of the end and the beginning of the eternal are so many. I struggle between them. Why? First, because prophecy regarding future events in some instances have gaps of time. There are, at other times, a blending together of separate events with no separation between them. Second, what the Lord is seeking to describe involves infinite truths delivered through finite words (God has revealed Himself truly to us but not yet completely). God uses truths that we know (events in the past, symbolic language) to explain what we do not know until it becomes a reality. Third, the Old Testament should not be read in isolation from the New Testament. The New Testament is the fulfillment of the Old, just as the Old anticipates the New. What is *enfolded* in the Old Testament is *unfolded* in the New Testament. Fourth, we must never forget that the storyline of the Bible is about the triumph of Jesus Christ, the reversal of the curse of the fall, the defeat of all evil, and the eternal abode of His people, gathered by His grace and provision at the cross, to live in His presence and worship Him forever. The point of the Bible is the glorification of God through the gathering of a people to Him forever. Fifth, we must not wring our allegorical hands over the details of when and how all this will happen, missing the real point, but find rest and peace in a troubled culture knowing the fact that He is the capstone of history. When we experience the future, it will be just as the Bible describes. Hope is not in the details, nor contrary to them, but in a person: the King of Kings and Lord of Lords.

Scripture Passage: Zechariah 7–8

Memory Verse: “This is what the LORD Almighty says: ‘I am very jealous for Zion; I am burning with jealousy for her.’” (Zechariah 8:2)

Basic Truth 11: Why was it necessary for Christ, the Redeemer, to die?

Lesson Highlights

Main Truth

God calls people to love Him—not just keep His laws.

- God’s people had returned from exile to Jerusalem and were working to rebuild the temple. The people of Bethel asked the priests and prophets if they should continue to mourn and fast as they had in exile. Zechariah received God’s answer. God asked if the people had mourned, fasted, and feasted for Him or for themselves all those years (Zechariah 7:1-7).
- God said He wanted His people to show justice and mercy to one another. He had given this same message to them in the past, but they did not listen. They had made their hearts hard until He had become angry and scattered them (Zechariah 7:8-14).
- Through Zechariah, God said He was jealous for His people. He promised to return to Jerusalem to live with them. He said old people and children would enjoy Jerusalem again, and He would be faithful and righteous to His people (Zechariah 8:1-8).
- God said to build the temple. He promised to bless His people with crops and save them to be a blessing to others. He said He had determined to do good for them, so they should not be afraid but speak truth and treat each other well (Zechariah 8:9-17).
- God said His people’s fasts would become joyful. He told them to love truth and peace. He said many peoples and powerful nations would come to Jerusalem seeking Him (Zechariah 8:18-23).

God’s Attribute

Jealous: God protectively loves His people.

- God’s jealousy is not like human jealousy. He does not feel insecure about His relationship with His children. Instead, God’s jealousy is a protective love and righteous anger toward His people when they choose to give Him little time and attention (Exodus 20:4-6; 34:14; Deuteronomy 4:24-31).
- When God’s people turn away from Him, He pursues them (Zechariah 1:3; Luke 19:10).

Gospel Connection

Because of Jesus, believers can enjoy a loving relationship with God.

- Jesus died to deliver people from the grip of sin, death, and hell and bring us back to God. He welcomes all who come to Him (Matthew 11:28-29; Romans 5:9-11; 2 Corinthians 5:19; Revelation 3:20).
- Through Jesus, the promised Messiah, believers can approach God as His dearly loved children (Matthew 1:21; Ephesians 3:8-12, 16-21; Hebrews 4:14-16; 1 John 3:1-3).

People of the Promise: Exile & Return

